

First Chapter Checklist

Twelve checks before anyone else reads page one.

A The promise Chapter one is a contract. These four clauses must be in it.

- ☐ **The voice is established in the first paragraph.**
Readers buy the telling before the tale. The voice is the first thing they taste.
- ☐ **The genre is signaled early.**
A thriller that opens like a pastoral breaks trust before the story begins.
- ☐ **The central question is planted.**
The reader should know what they are waiting to find out.
- ☐ **The point of view is unmistakable.**
Confusion about whose head we are in kills momentum on page one.

B The disturbance Something must already be wrong, or about to be.

- ☐ **Normal is broken by page _____**
Write your own deadline in the blank. Stasis described at length is stasis endured at length.
- ☐ **The protagonist wants something on page one.**
Even a glass of water gives the scene a direction to lean.
- ☐ **No weather opening, no waking up, no mirror.**
The three most common opening clichés. Editors spot them in one line.
- ☐ **The stakes are hinted, even faintly.**
Curiosity needs a reason to care, not just a reason to wonder.

C The craft The invisible work that makes the visible work land.

- ☐ **The chapter starts as late as possible.**
Arrive after the boring part already happened.
- ☐ **Backstory stays under two sentences.**
The reader has not earned the past yet, and neither has the story.
- ☐ **One concrete sensory detail grounds the scene.**
A single smell or texture does more than a paragraph of scenery.
- ☐ **The chapter ends on a hook question.**
A chapter break is an exit. Give the reader a reason not to take it.

THE QUESTION MY READER LEAVES CHAPTER ONE HOLDING
